Winning and Losing

By Donald Davis

DONALD: **(Pg 23-24)** For six years I had waited for this day to arrive. I was going to school! It was Tuesday, the day after Labor Day. Mother got me up with orders to take a bath.

MOTHER: You've got to at least start out clean. We don't want any of the teachers to get you mixed up with those nasty short-necked Rabbit Creek boys.

DONALD: So I was scrubbed, then dressed in a brand-new pair of blue jeans so stiff I could barely move my knees. *(demonstrate)* Every time I tried to sit down, they tried to stand me up again! The outfit was topped off by a new shirt with a collar that felt like the edge of a tin can. *(move neck uncomfortably)*

Daddy drove Mother and me to Sulpher Springs School on his way to work – a school that looked like a school in a story book. All red brick with three sets of tall, white columns. Mother and I went into the auditorium for the assembling of new first graders. I had never seen such a

4NG Fanatics

big room. *(look around in awe)* It was bigger than the inside of our church!

INTRODUCTION

Donald Davis was born in 1944 in a Southern Appalachian mountain world rich in stories. His career as a storyteller has carried him all over the nation and the world. But his stories never stray far from his family who have occupied the same land in Haywood County, NC for over two centuries. In this selection Mr. Davis takes us back to a simpler time – 1950 . . . when a six-year-old learns his first lesson about

Winning and Losing by Donald Davis

DONALD: **(Pg 24-25)** There were rows and rows and rows of wooden seats with curved backs and seat bottoms which folded up and down making a loud "clunk" each time you dared move them. Mother and I were almost exactly in the center of our row. We were not alone. On this day there were more than a hundred new first graders, more than a hundred mamas and, I think, three daddies. Our row was packed.

Finally the stage curtain began to open. There, standing center stage was Mr. Lonnie Underhill. [He] began to welcome us to the first grade and tell us all the things we

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

needed to know for success at Sulpher Springs School: School spirit, behavior rules, school buses, how to pay for lunch, rules about vaccinations and absences. Mr. Underhill's speech went on and on and on.

At last, he began to introduce the first-grade teachers. First was Miss Caldwell. It was the first of four good, long, substantial introductions we were to hear that day.

MR. UNDERHILL: . . . Miss Caldwell was just born with teaching right in her blood.

DONALD: *(Begin to wiggle, cross legs)* About this time, I began to realize I did not know where the bathroom was. Even if I had known . . . trapped in the very center of row G, there was no way out! Mr. Underhill finished his last introduction. ***Maybe we'll get to go now.***

MR. UNDERHILL: **(Pg 26-27)** Now, children. We still have a lot of housekeeping to take care of. We have to call the roll.

DONALD: With every name he called, the bathroom crisis got worse. *(uncomfortableness increases)*

MR. UNDERHILL: Setzer . . . Smith . . . Summey . . .

4NG Fanatics

DONALD: I could not possibly be dry by the time we got out of this place! I began to try every trick I could think of to relieve the pain in my bladder. *(tighten hand into fist, grit teeth, hold breath)* In desperation I tried to think of something good about all this. Suddenly I got it! ***I am wearing brand-new, dark blue, unfaded blue jeans. I won't look nearly as wet in these as I would in old, faded jeans!***

Mr. Underhill and the teachers had finished calling the roll and determined that all students from Patricia Abernethy to Thoms Greene will be in Miss Caldwell's room. ***That's me! If we go now, I can make it!*** But it was not to be. It was time for Mr. Underhill's first-day-of-school principal speech.

MR. UNDERHILL: Life, boys and girls, is made up of two things: WINNING and LOSING.

DONALD: He was right, and I was about to lose . . .

MR. UNDERHILL: The most important thing is that you do a lot more losing than winning. But, once in a while you do get to win. And when that time finally comes, it is so

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

good that you forget all about the losing you did to get there.

DONALD: I began my own version of losing --first a drop, then a trickle, then a little squirt. Then I thought, ***If you're going to wet your pants, go ahead and do it right!*** So I did! *(wets pants with a sigh of pure relief; looks down)* The new blue jeans had worked! I looked completely dry. If I could slip out of here sideways, with my back to the wall, no one would ever know. [Except. .]

The floor of the auditorium sloped from the back toward the front. I could see kids in front of me punch one another as they looked down and pointed at the mysterious stream of water making its way down the sloping floor toward the growing puddle that was building into a lake in front of the stage.

Just when I was sure Mr. Underhill would demand to know who that came from, he suddenly dismissed us to our rooms. *(wipes brown in relief)* **(Pg 28)** I walked sideways with my back to the wall, certain I was going to make it there and get seated before anyone discovered I was wet. [But] it was necessary to turn momentarily to

4NG Fanatics

go into Miss Caldwell's door. And in that brief unguarded moment . . .

CARRIE BOYD: Look! That little boy wet his pants!

DONALD: I thought I was going to die. She knows!

MR. UNDERHILL: *(echoing)* Life is made up of winning and losing . . . and there's a lot more losing than winning.

CARRIE BOYD: **(Pg 35)** There's water dripping out of your britches leg! HA, HA, HA!

DONALD: No conscious thought went into what happened next. The reaction her words inspired was much too fast for thought to have been involved. My right hand clenched itself tightly into a hard little fist and shot out – smack! – striking Carrie Boyd full force in the mouth.

The entire room was silent. In the moment before her scream, we heard a little "plunk," as one of her big front teeth fell out of her ugly mouth.

(Pg 36) I never knew what happened next as Miss Caldwell glided with me all the way to Mr. Underhill's office. After a short speech, I was deposited in a chair until the bell finally rang and we all went home. Mother knew. I could tell the moment I saw her. I saved myself

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

some time by going to the maple tree in the back yard and breaking off a switch before I even went into the house. Without saying a word, she gave me a pretty good switching right through those wet britches.

MOTHER: You ought to be ashamed of yourself. Now change your clothes and wait for your Daddy to get home.

DONALD: Finally I heard the Dodge come in the driveway. Daddy was home. *(heavy sigh – to Dad)* Go ahead and whip me and get it over with.

DADDY: I'm not going to whip you. You've had enough of that. But you're going to have to walk up to Carrie Boyd's house and apologize to her parents for knocking her tooth out.

DONALD: *(to Dad almost crying, frantic)* No! Please just whip me and get it over with. Whip me every day for a week. Just don't make me go up there.

DADDY: *(points in the direction of the Boyd's)*

DONALD: **(Pg 37-38)** The Boyds' house was less than a half-mile from ours but it took me two hours to walk up there. I would take a few steps, then stop to think about it for a while. At last I got to the Boyds' Mr. Boyd had a yellow

4NG Fanatics

Piper Cub airplane which he kept in the hay barn. I knew he would be there working on the airplane. Both Mr. and Mrs Boyd looked at me as I walked slowly into their presence.

My knees would hardly hold, my chin quivered, my eyes filled with tears . . . I stood before them for a long uncomfortable minute while they looked down at me and didn't say a word. I had never talked to either of them before in my entire life.

(To the Boyds' -- whimpering) I'm sorry . . . I'm sorry that I knocked Carrie's tooth out. *(crying hard)*

The Boyds didn't say a word. They just looked at one another, at me, at one another again. Then, as if in slow motion, Mr. Boyd reached into his hip pocket and pulled out his wallet. He took out one of the first real five dollar bills I have ever seen close-up.

MR. BOYD: That tooth? That tooth was a baby tooth. It's been hanging there by a thread for two months. Carrie wouldn't let either one of touch it. *(laughing)* Thank you for finally getting that thing out!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

DONALD: He handed me the five-dollar bill.

Suddenly I remembered Mr. Underhill's speech, and I knew that he was right. Life is made up of winning and losing, and like he said, "When you finally get to win, it's so good, you forget all the losing you've done to get there!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Donald Davis
Book: Ride the Butterflies, Pg 23-38
ISBN: 978-0874836066
Publisher: August House
Date (Month/Year): Dec 2005

AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier – MS
2021 National Qualifier – MS

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY